

DEMAS AND THE DRIFT

When Good Work Replaces First Love

Atlanta North Vespers

DETAILED FACILITATOR COPY | 60 MINUTES

FACILITATOR ANCHOR

***“Demas did not stop working.
He stopped loving rightly.”***

Keep this sentence visible all evening. Everything builds toward it. Everything after it flows from it.

PRE-SESSION SETUP CHECKLIST

☐	Room & Environment Soft instrumental music playing as people arrive. Room dimmed slightly. No bright overhead glare.
☐	Technology Mentimeter account open on facilitator device. QR codes ready on screen (or printed). Clicker / slide advancer in hand.
☐	Materials Printed copies of the three Demas texts (Col 4:14, Phm 1:24, 2 Tim 4:10) for any attendee who wants them. Optional reflection cards.
☐	Your Personal Setup This facilitator copy printed and tabbed by section. Highlighter for live notes. Water.
☐	Scripture Slides Three slides: Col 4:14 → Phm 1:24 → 2 Tim 4:10. No other text on the slides.
☐	Opening Prayer Prepared and personal — frame it around clarity of affection, not clarity of thought.
☐	Whiteboard / Screen Blank and ready for the icebreaker word capture.

SESSION TIMELINE AT A GLANCE

Section	Clock	Activity	Key Move
1	0:00–0:05	Opening prayer + silence	Frame: clarity of affection
2	0:05–0:13	Icebreaker + QR Pulse #1	Diagnostic self-awareness
3	0:13–0:23	Scripture: Three Mentions of Demas	The arc is the whole point
4	0:23–0:31	Clinical Frame + Blog Excerpt	Name the diagnosis
5	0:31–0:43	Core Tension: Good Work vs. First Love	Both truths held together
6	0:43–0:51	Biblical Reorientation + Sabbath	The Sabbath as rescue, not rule
7	0:51–0:58	QR Pulse #3 + Private Reflection	Honest personal inventory
8	0:58–1:00	Group Commitment + Closing	One practical reorder

1. OPENING

5 MIN

FACILITATOR NOTE

You are setting a tone, not delivering information. The slower and quieter you are at the start, the deeper the room will go later. Resist the urge to warm things up with energy. This program works in the opposite direction: start still, build slowly.

Room should already have soft instrumental playing when people arrive. Do not rush to begin. When about 90% of seats are filled, give it 60 more seconds, then move.

SAY THIS

[Allow silence for 20 seconds after people settle. Then begin the prayer without announcing it.]

Pray for clarity of affection, not clarity of thought. Something like:

“Lord, before we think about Demas tonight — we ask that You would first search our own hearts. Not our schedules, not our to-do lists — but what we love. Who we love. We want You to be first. Show us if You’re not.”

[Pause after prayer. Let it breathe. Then, without slides, say:]

“Tonight is not about judging Demas. It is about recognizing how close we are to him.”

[Do not move on immediately. Let that sentence sit for 10–15 seconds. Then proceed to Section 2.]

IF/THEN — RESPONSE GUIDE

If someone looks confused or like they want clarification right away:

Do not explain it yet. Nod warmly and say: “We’ll get there.” This is intentional ambiguity. Let it do its work.

2. ICEBREAKER + QR PULSE #1: “The Diagnostic Opening”

8 MIN

FACILITATOR NOTE

This section is diagnostic before it is didactic. You are not teaching yet — you are helping the room see itself. The Mentimeter results will show them as a group what each individual privately knows about themselves. That collective mirror is powerful.

Have the whiteboard or digital screen ready for the verbal responses. Write actual words — not summaries. If someone says “my startup,” write “my startup.” Specificity creates identification.

SAY THIS

VERBAL WARM-UP [2 min]

“Let’s start here. What are you currently building or pursuing? Don’t overthink it — just name it.”

Take 3–4 answers aloud. Write them on the board or screen exactly as said. Career. Business. Ministry. Personal growth. Let the room own its reality.

QR PULSE #1 — Display on screen, ask attendees to scan

“Right now, what gets most of your daily attention?”

- Christ and devotional life
- Career and professional growth
- Relationships and family
- Personal goals and self-development

Tool: Mentimeter poll. Display results live immediately.

Do NOT comment on the results immediately. Just let them see themselves as a group. Hold the silence for 5–8 seconds.

SAY THIS

[After results are displayed, pause. Then ask — do NOT answer:]

“Which of these could slowly replace Christ — without you even noticing?”

[Let it sit. Do not fill the silence. Count to eight in your head. Then transition to Section 3.]

IF/THEN — RESPONSE GUIDE

If someone immediately answers the question — which breaks the silence:

Receive the answer graciously: “Good — hold that thought. We’re going to come back to exactly that.” Then hold the pause before moving on.

If the results show that most attention is on Christ (first option):

Don’t challenge it directly. Simply say: “That’s good. And tonight is for all of us — because Demas probably would have said the same thing three years before 2 Timothy.”

3. SCRIPTURE: The Three Mentions of Demas

10 MIN

FACILITATOR NOTE

The arc is the entire theological argument. Do not rush it. Read each verse yourself — do not ask someone from the audience to read tonight. Your voice, your pacing, controls the weight.

Project each slide one at a time. Pause between them. The silence between Colossians and 2 Timothy should feel long enough to be slightly uncomfortable. That discomfort is the point.

SAY THIS

Read these three texts slowly. One at a time. Pause after each.

“Colossians 4:14 — Demas the co-laborer. Present. Trusted. Named.”

[Pause 5 seconds. Advance slide.]

“Philemon 1:24 — Still in the inner circle. Still working.”

[Pause 8 seconds. Advance slide. Longer pause here — build the tension.]

“2 Timothy 4:10 — ‘Having loved this present world.’”

[Pause. Then:]

“Paul doesn’t say Demas became wicked. He says Demas loved something else more.”

INTERACTIVE PAIRS [3 min]

“Turn to one person near you. I want you to talk through this question together for two minutes.”

“Did Demas fall suddenly — or drift gradually? What do you think happened between Colossians and 2 Timothy?”

After 2 minutes, gather 2–3 brief share-backs from the room. You are listening for the word “gradual.” When someone uses it or implies it, validate and build:

SAY THIS

[After share-backs, land the key insight:]

“This was not an acute collapse. This was a chronic condition of the soul.”

[Pause. Let it land. Then transition: “Let’s look at that diagnosis more carefully.”]

IF/THEN — RESPONSE GUIDE

If someone argues Demas was simply weak or immoral:

Affirm the concern: “That’s a reasonable read. What’s interesting is that Paul doesn’t use moral language — he uses the language of love. That distinction is going to matter for us in a few minutes.”

If someone asks whether Demas was restored:

Honest answer: “We don’t know. The text goes silent. And that silence is its own warning.”

4. THE CLINICAL FRAME: “Differential Diagnosis of Demas”

8 MIN

FACILITATOR NOTE

This section uses clinical language deliberately — this is an Adventist audience of professionals. The “Differential Diagnosis” framing from your blog post meets them in their world and then turns that world upside down.

Read the excerpt slowly. Do not rush. The formal, clinical tone contrasts beautifully with the personal weight of the topic. Let the contrast do its work.

After the reading, the QR Pulse will surface what the room is already thinking. The goal is not to teach the diagnosis — it’s to help them name it themselves.

SAY THIS

[Say before reading the excerpt:]

“I want to read you something I wrote earlier this year. I want you to listen as a clinician listens — and then tell me what you’d put on the chart.”

[Read the selected excerpt from “Differential Diagnosis of Demas.” Read at 70% of your normal speaking speed.]

QR PULSE #2 — After the blog reading

“What do you think is the primary diagnosis for Demas?”

- Burnout and spiritual exhaustion
- Gradual distraction by success
- Loss of devotional discipline
- Misplaced love — loving a good thing too much

Tool: Mentimeter word cloud or poll.

When results display, say: “Notice what this room just said. This is a room of people who have thought about this.” Then affirm the range without resolving it yet.

SOURCE

Ellen White — Testimonies for the Church, Vol. 5, p. 161

“Many are so absorbed in business that they have no time for prayer, no time for the study of the Bible... The cares of this life crowd out the things of eternity.”

[You may read this quote now or hold it for Section 5. Either works. If the room is tracking well on the diagnosis theme, read it here and let it close this section.]

IF/THEN — RESPONSE GUIDE

If most votes go to “Burnout and spiritual exhaustion”:

Affirm and reframe: “That’s real. And Paul’s word choice points even deeper than exhaustion. He doesn’t say Demas was tired. He says Demas was in love — with the wrong thing. Burnout can be a symptom of that misplaced love.”

If the room lands hard on “Misplaced love”:

Build on it immediately: “That’s exactly where we’re going. Hold onto that.”

5. THE CORE TENSION: Good Work vs. First Love

12 MIN

FACILITATOR NOTE

This is the theological center of the evening. Twelve minutes is short for what you're attempting. Do not let it become a lecture. Present the two truths plainly, let the small groups wrestle, then gather the Adventist-specific application.

The tension between these two truths is not a problem to resolve. It is the permanent condition of the Christian professional life. Name it as such.

The Adventist stakes question at the end of this section is load-bearing. Do not skip it or soften it.

SAY THIS

[Present these two statements side-by-side, verbally and on slide if possible:]

Statement 1: “God calls us to meaningful work in the world.”

Statement 2: “The world can quietly replace God in our hearts.”

“Both of these are true. The tension between them is not a contradiction. It is the permanent condition of the Christian professional life. And Demas is what happens when we stop holding the tension.”

SOURCE

The Great Controversy, p. 508 (verify page in your edition)

“Satan works to distort the character of God — often making Him seem harsh or unloving — to distract humans, breaking their focus and preventing a close, personal relationship with Him.”

SMALL GROUPS — 3 to 4 people [4 min]**Question 1:**

“How do you know when your work is still worship — and when it has become replacement?”

Question 2:

“What does loving Christ practically look like in a busy professional life?”

Gather 2–3 insights from the room after group time. Listen especially for practical, specific answers. Affirm those. Resist the pull toward abstract answers.

SAY THIS

[After gathering insights, deliver the Adventist stakes question. Say it slowly. It is the pivot of the evening:]

“If the final crisis is about worship and allegiance — not activity — then Demas is not a cautionary tale about slacking off. He is a cautionary tale about what we worship while we work.”

[Pause. Do not move immediately. Then:]

“He kept working. He lost the inner life while the outer life kept going.”

SOURCE

Ellen White — *Steps to Christ*, p. 44

“It is not so much the fear of punishment, or the hope of everlasting reward, that leads the disciples of Christ to follow Him. They behold the Saviour’s matchless love... and to them duty becomes a delight and sacrifice a pleasure.”

IF/THEN — RESPONSE GUIDE

If someone objects: “But isn’t working hard for God the same as loving God?”

Use the Ephesus parallel: “Revelation 2 speaks to a church that worked harder than any other. Deeds, labor, perseverance — all there. But Christ says, ‘I have this against you: you have left your first love.’ It is possible to do God’s work and lose God’s heart.”

If someone asks: “How do you recalibrate once you’ve drifted?”

Hold the answer: “That’s exactly where we’re going next.” This prevents Section 5 from bleeding into Section 6.

6. BIBLICAL REORIENTATION: Christ at the Center

8 MIN

FACILITATOR NOTE

This section provides the theological corrective. Two texts, then the Adventist-specific application of the Sabbath. Do not rush the Sabbath section — it is not an add-on. It is the practical answer to the question the whole evening has been raising.

The Sabbath reframe here is positive, not legalistic. You are presenting it as rescue, not rule. If it sounds like a command, you have lost the room. If it sounds like relief, you have won it.

SAY THIS

[Project Matthew 6:21 and read it:]

“Where your treasure is, there your heart will be also.”

[Pause. Then project Revelation 2:4 and read it:]

“You have left your first love.”

[Long pause. Then:]

“These are two sides of the same coin. What you treasure reveals where your heart is. And Christ is saying to Ephesus — and to us — that the heart has moved. Not dramatically. Just... gradually.”

SOURCE

Ellen White — The Acts of the Apostles, p. 547

“The church of Ephesus had let slip her first love. She was more intent on carrying on the forms and ceremonies of religion than on possessing its spirit. She was more anxious to win the approval of men than to win the approval of God.”

SAY THIS

[The Sabbath move. Say this as if you're offering someone water:]

“The Sabbath is God’s built-in resistance against becoming Demas.”

[Pause. Then unpack it:]

“Not a rule. A rescue.”

“It interrupts identity through achievement. It interrupts constant striving. It interrupts the creeping replacement of God by good things.”

“And it recenters: relationship over performance. Trust over productivity. Devotion over deliverables.”

“Demas kept working. He lost the Sabbath of the soul first.”

SOURCE

Ellen White — Testimonies for the Church, Vol. 6, p. 350

“The Sabbath is not intended to be a period of useless inactivity. The law forbids secular labor on the rest day of the Lord; the toil that gains a livelihood must cease; but the work of ministry is not to cease.”

Ellen White — The Desire of Ages, p. 289

“Jesus did not release men from keeping the Sabbath; He showed what its true observance should be.”

IF/THEN — RESPONSE GUIDE

If someone pushes back: “But I feel close to God in my work.”

Affirm it fully: “Good — that’s exactly what Sabbath is trying to protect and sustain. It’s not saying your work is not worship. It’s saying: don’t let the work become the whole relationship.”

If someone asks about the Sabbath format (what to do, what not to do):

Redirect gently: “That’s a great question for another night. Tonight I want us to stay at the level of the heart, not the schedule.”

7. QR PULSE #3 + PERSONAL REFLECTION

7 MIN

FACILITATOR NOTE

This is the most private and most important section. Protect the silence. The QR Pulse surfaces honest self-assessment; the private reflection moment is between each person and God.

Do not fill the reflection time with ambient narration. Simply announce the question, tell them it’s private, and then be silent for two full minutes. The silence feels uncomfortable to you as a facilitator. That is fine. Stay in it.

After the reflection time, do not ask people to share what they wrote. Honor the privacy you promised.

QR PULSE #3 — Open text / word cloud

“What is competing with Christ for your deepest affection right now?”

Display results. Do not analyze or comment on individual entries. Simply let the word cloud speak.

SAY THIS

[After displaying results, say quietly:]

“I think what we’re seeing here... is that we are all closer to Demas than we thought.”

[Pause. Then:]

“I want to give you two minutes. On your phone or a piece of paper — not to share, just for yourself and God — answer this:”

PRIVATE REFLECTION — DO NOT SHARE

“What would it look like to choose Christ first this week? Not in general. This week.”

This is between them and God. Protect that.

FACILITATOR NOTE

[Hold silence for a full two minutes. Set a quiet timer if helpful. Do not speak. Do not move around the room. Stand still and let the silence work.]

8. GROUP COMMITMENT + CLOSING

5 MIN

FACILITATOR NOTE

Keep this section short. You have done the heavy lifting. The close is landing, not restating. Two to three voluntary shares, then the lingering question, then prayer.

The lingering question is the most important thing they leave with tonight. Say it slowly and do NOT answer it. Let it travel home with them.

SAY THIS

“Before we close, I want to invite two or three people to share: what is one practical way you’re going to reorder your life toward Christ this coming week? Not a spiritual aspiration — something specific.”

[Seed with examples if the room needs them:]

EXAMPLES TO SEED IF NEEDED

- Protecting morning devotional time before reaching for the phone
- Reframing work as service to others, not as the source of my identity
- Guarding the Sabbath more intentionally this week — specific, not vague
- One scheduled conversation with God about what has been competing for His place

SAY THIS

[After 2–3 shares, deliver the lingering question. Slow. Deliberate. No slides.]

“If someone wrote one sentence about your spiritual life five years from now — would it sound more like Colossians... or 2 Timothy?”

[Do not answer it. Do not comment on it. Let it sit for 8 full seconds. Then:]

“Let’s close in prayer.”

[Pray for reordered love. Not for success. Not for productivity. Not for blessing on their work. For love rightly ordered.]

APPENDIX A: QR DEPLOYMENT SUMMARY

Pulse #	Moment	Question	Tool	Purpose
#1	After icebreaker	What gets most of your daily attention?	Mentimeter poll	Self-diagnostic
#2	After Demas reading	What is Demas's diagnosis?	Word cloud	Clinical framing
#3	Personal reflection	What competes with Christ right now?	Open text / word cloud	Honest confession

FACILITATOR NOTE

Use Mentimeter for the word cloud moments. Use Google Forms if you want written responses to review afterward. For Pulse #3, consider keeping responses anonymous even from yourself — this protects the safety of honest confession.

APPENDIX B: ELLEN WHITE QUICK REFERENCE

Theme	Source	Quote (abbreviated)
Leaving First Love	Acts of the Apostles, p. 547	<i>"She was more intent on carrying on the forms and ceremonies of religion than on possessing its spirit..."</i>
Activity Replacing Devotion	Testimonies, Vol. 5, p. 161	<i>"Many are so absorbed in business that they have no time for prayer..."</i>
Gradual Drift / Distraction	The Great Controversy, p. 508*	<i>"Satan works to distort the character of God... to distract humans..."</i>
Love as Foundation of True Work	Steps to Christ, p. 44	<i>"...to them duty becomes a delight and sacrifice a pleasure."</i>
Sabbath as Corrective (1)	Testimonies, Vol. 6, p. 350	<i>"The Sabbath is not intended to be a period of useless inactivity..."</i>
Sabbath as Corrective (2)	The Desire of Ages, p. 289	<i>"Jesus did not release men from keeping the Sabbath; He showed what its true observance should be."</i>

*Verify page number in your specific edition of *The Great Controversy*.

APPENDIX C: POST-SESSION FACILITATOR NOTES**FACILITATOR NOTE**

Use this space during or after the session to capture:

- Moments that landed particularly well — and why
- Questions or pushback you weren't fully prepared for

- Names of individuals who seemed especially moved — for follow-up
- What you would cut, expand, or reorder for the next time
- The dominant word cloud entries from Pulses #2 and #3

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